The decision to blockade thus emerged as a collage. Its pieces included the initial decision by the President that something forceful had to be done; the resistance of Robert Kennedy, McNamara, and Sorensen to the air strike; the relative distance between the President and the air strike advocates; and a probably inaccurate piece of information.[*]

A Dilemma of Governance

The process of decision in this case illustrates a set of checks and balances almost unmentioned by our Constitution. A President and his top-level associates are mutually dependent. But their needs of one another can be incompatible. Rarely do they serve each other to their mutual satisfaction. Robert Kennedy's account suggests that in the Cuban missile crisis satisfaction was indeed obtained by both. A careful reading will suggest, however, the fragility of this result. It is not to be taken for granted.

What President Kennedy needed from executive officialdom is plain in his brother's story. He needed information, analysis, and control to match his own unshared and now unshareable responsibility. In retrospect he seems to have received enough of each, but only just, and only by extraordinary effort on his own part and on that of his most intimate associates. The U-2 photographs were taken in the nick of time for him; our aircraft lined up wing-to-wing were not dispersed until he intervened; his agent McNamara never did succeed in wresting from the Navy full control over its ships, and only Soviet caution saved him from the consequences of an Air Force pilot's fix on the wrong star. What he needed, evidently, was information building up from small details and control reaching down to small decisions in the depths of every relevant department. These were his needs because the country and its future depended so heavily on his judgment.

What top officials needed from the President is also plain in RFK's account of the Ex Comm. They needed a forum for discussion, a referee for arguments, assurance of a hearing, and a judgment on disputes. Their jurisdictions were at once divided and entangled. The Secretaries of Defense and State, the military services, the CIA, our missions at the United Nations and at NATO all had roles to play, but these required each to share the stage with all the rest. None could act alone. And their perspectives were parochial (at least in in some degree). The Air Force saw the interest of the nation—and its options—in terms diametrically opposed to those of our Ambassador at the United Nations. The